

move could put more pressure on the CPI(M) to show flexibility on the Telangana issue. Of the four possible partners, only the CPI(M) still maintains its strict opposition to a separate state, fearing the boost pro-Gorkhaland forces could get in West Bengal. That makes it imperative for every party to take a stand on it, considering that the TRS has pursued separate statehood for the last seven years, despite internal strife, divisions and, ultimately, a parting of the ways with the Congress.

Naidu is taking his party's strategic switch forward by communicating the TDP decision to the UPA sub-committee headed by External Affairs Minister Pranab Mukherjee that has been trying

dent M. Venkaiah Naidu has declared that Telangana will be formed within 100 days of the NDA coming to power at the Centre.

Naidu now accuses the Congress of repeatedly raking up the "separate state issue" and failing to deliver. "History is replete with instances wherein the Congress raised the demand for separate states for political gains," says Naidu, "but on assuming power, both in the state and the Centre, it conveniently ignored Telangana issue." He is also stepping up his forays into Telangana,

BALLOT BATTLE: (Left) Chief Minister Rajasekhara Reddy and PRP chief Chiranjeevi



THE CONGRESS CHIEF MINISTER HAS STRONG SUPPORT IN RAYALASEEMA, AND CHIRANJEEVI'S PRP IS GAINING AT THE EXPENSE OF NAIDU'S PARTY.

to evolve a consensus on the issue. "He should have taken it three years ago if he was sincere," says state Congress chief Dharmapuri Srinivas, admitting the move puts pressure on the UPA to act quickly. It's a tough call for the Congress: Go through the motions, like adopting an Assembly resolution for the creation of Telangana, or consider legislation in the Lok Sabha. It may even use Telangana as a trigger for a second round of reorganisation of states.

The BJP, which advocates a separate Telangana, is trying to make the most of it. Party leader and former Union minister Ch. Vidyasagar Rao has urged all pro-Telangana parties to exert more pressure on the UPA to take all measures for making the necessary law in the next session of Parliament so that Telangana can be formed in 2009. The more optimistic former party presi-

his strategic switch underlined by the need to forge a non-Congress alliance as the prospect of the PRP joining hands with the TDP is remote. Naidu's gamble may not pay off as the TRS and the communist parties are keeping the other option open—to sail with the PRP if Chiranjeevi is a hit across Andhra Pradesh. The prospects of Naidu's potential allies moving towards Chiranjeevi are high.

The TDP chief's only comfort factor is that the actors in the N.T. Rama Rao's family back him because of their opposition to Chiranjeevi. But the chance of deeper isolation dims Naidu's and the TDP's future. Only an electoral understanding that binds the TDP's allies together can help him take on and overcome the Congress and the PRP.

Naidu's road is tough, and it will take some going through Telangana. ■